

Free Will and the Unconscious

Many activities in everyday life—from our movements to our emotions—are not controlled consciously. Instead, unconscious activity in the brain is behind a lot of our actions, thoughts, and behaviors.

Free will

The ability to choose a course of action without restriction is called free will, and it may seem that we use our conscious mind to make these decisions. However, research suggests that we may have less conscious control over our actions than we think. Experiments have shown that our brain begins to plan a movement one-fifth of a second before we consciously decide to make a move.

CAN YOUR UNCONSCIOUS HELP YOU SOLVE A PROBLEM?

If you are stuck on a problem, letting your mind wander can allow the brain to collect information from your unconscious and potentially provide a solution.

Benjamin Libet's experiment

Scientist Benjamin Libet instructed his subjects to note down when they became conscious of their decision to raise a finger. At the same time, their brain waves and muscle movements were recorded.

